"IN THE BEGINNING..."

GENESIS 34

IN 5 MINUTES

When:

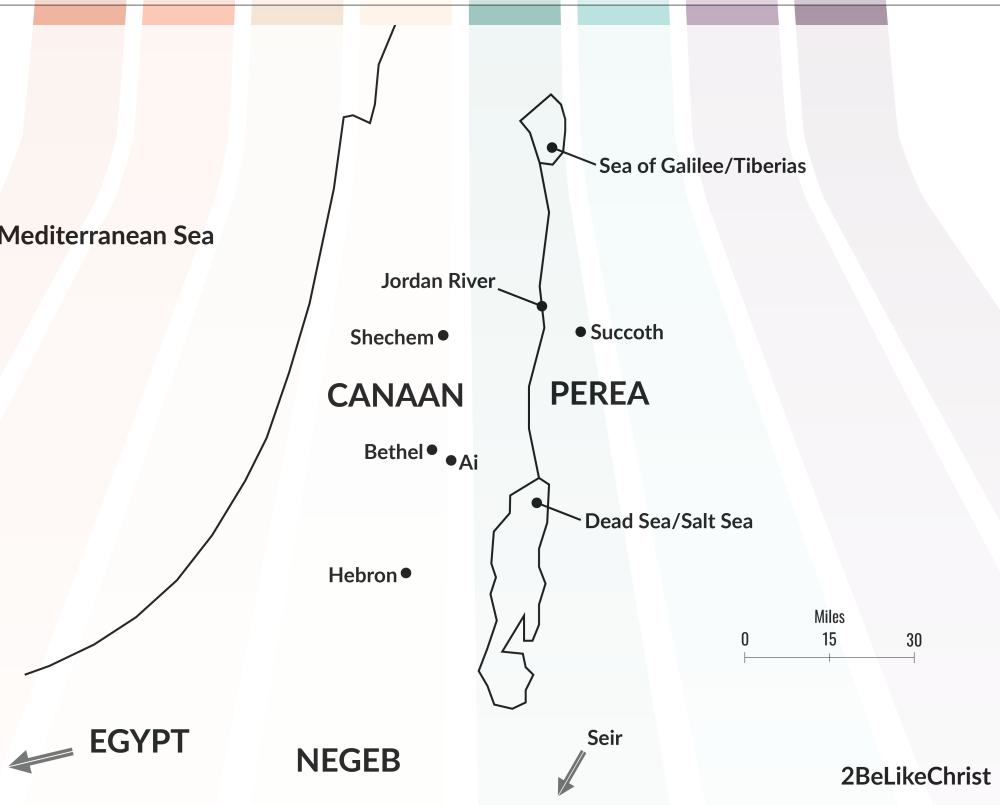
- We don't have enough details to date the events of this chapter with precision.
- It's likely the events of Genesis 34 took place shortly after Jacob's return to Canaan, sometime between 1745-1725 B.C.

Characters:

- Jacob – The son of Isaac and Rebekah and twin brother of Esau. He had recently returned from Haran to dwell in Canaan.
- Dinah – Jacob's daughter with Leah (30:21).
- Hamor – A ruler of the city of Shechem from the family of the Hivites.
- Shechem – Son of Hamor. He is described as the "prince of the land."
- Simeon – Jacob's second oldest son. He was the son of Leah.
- Levi – Jacob's third oldest son. He was the son of Leah.

Where:

- The story in Genesis 24 played out near the city of Shechem in the land of Canaan (33:18-19).
- Keep in mind, "Shechem" is the name of a city AND the name of a key character in this chapter.



Outline:

- DINAH, JACOB'S DAUGHTER, IS DEFILED (34:1-4):
    + While Dinah, the daughter of Leah and Jacob, was out visiting the women of the land, Shechem, "the prince of the land," seized her and raped her.
    + Shechem became obsessed with Dinah and asked his father, Hamor, to get her for him as a wife.
- JACOB'S SONS TRICK HAMOR INTO MAKING A PACT WITH THEM (34:5-18):
    + When Dinah's brothers heard what had happened to their sister, they were furious, but they held their peace when Hamor and Shechem came to speak with Jacob.
    + Hamor proposed a treaty between Jacob's family and the people of his land.
    + He invited Jacob's sons to marry their women and trade amongst them.
    + Shechem offered to pay any bride-price Jacob wanted for Dinah.
    + Jacob's sons pretended to agree with Hamor's proposal but told him they would only accept if he and all his people were circumcised.
    + Hamor agreed to their terms.
- LEVI AND SIMEON ATTACK HAMOR'S CITY (34:19-31):
    + Hamor returned to his city and convinced all the men to be circumcised.
    + Three days later, while the men were still healing, Levi and Simeon, two of Jacob's sons, attacked the city with swords and killed all the men.
    + They killed Hamor and Shechem and took Dinah back to Jacob's house.
    + They plundered the city and took all their wives, young children, and animals.
    + Jacob was angry with Simeon and Levi because he feared the people of the land would ally against their household and destroy them.

Application:

- This is not so much an application as it is an observation that's important to keep in mind as you read the Bible.
- The Bible doesn't always speak to the morality of the history it records.
- If you are like me, after reading this story you probably wanted to know God's thoughts on the matter.
- In God's eyes, were Levi and Simeon justified in their actions? Was their response to extreme? What did God think of Shechem's actions?
- In Genesis 34, God doesn't provide a definitive statement about who was right and who was wrong.
- In these instances, it's important for us to focus on the information we are given and to add it to the larger story God is telling us through these narratives.